What is your government's stand?
A. We are committed to balancing development and the environment. Let me state categorically—tribal interests will not suffer. The government is committed to bringing development to the most deprived. This is bound to bother the Congress and pseudo-activists.

Q. Though it is said that Maoism is on its last legs in Chhattisgarh, they still strike back. Is an end to Maoism in sight? Are you open to talks?
A. Setting up security camps, like most recently at Purvati in Sukma, is a central feature of anti-Maoist strategy. From the camp, the government has started a Niyad Nellanar scheme to deliver welfare schemes to locals. We will deal with Maoists with an iron hand. For talks, Maoists must first shun violence.

Q. The BJP made promises like paddy procurement at Rs 3,100 a quintal under Modi ki Guarantee. How will you raise resources for these new expenses?
A. The state has vast mineral resources and a conducive environment for investment. We have not introduced new taxes. The double engine model of governance will push the state from a Rs 5 lakh crore economy to Rs 10 lakh crore in the next five years.

Q. What is your strategy for the Lok Sabha polls? The Congress has just declared candidates, including former CM Bhupesh Baghel, for some seats.
A. The BJP and its workers are ready for elections at any given time. I am confident we will win all 11 seats in Chhattisgarh, irrespective of which candidates the Congress fields.

Q. Man-elephant conflict has assumed serious proportions in Chhattisgarh. What is being done about it?
A. Forest department staff is being provided necessary equipment to deal with elephants. A long-term solution is being worked upon, keeping in mind elephant habitat.

Q. You own a revolver and a double-barrelled gun. How did you become fond of firearms?
A. We come from a zamindar family. My ancestors were fond of hunting, and there were more than 10 guns in the family. I got them as a family legacy and retain them, but have never hunted. ■

housing scheme, wherein false claims are being made by the BJP government," says Shukla.

State finance minister O.P. Chaudhary, who had presented Chhattisgarh's budget for 2024-25 on February 27 has a clear idea of the focus areas of development. "Chhattisgarh is endowed with vast mineral wealth and natural resources. Our core sectors of strength are mining and mineral-based industries. There are non-core sectors like tourism, hospitality, IT and private health amenities that we have identified and which will see action," says Chaudhary. "We have set ourselves an ambitious target of doubling the state economy from Rs 5 lakh crore to Rs 10 lakh crore by 2028," he adds.

Of course, there is the not-so-minor matter of funding the welfare schemes—in the state budget, there is a provision of Rs 8,369 for construction of houses under the PM Awas Yojana, Rs 10,000 crore under the Krishak Unnati Yojana and Rs 4,500 crore under the Jal Jeevan Mission, to name just three.

"No state, after having committed itself to fulfilling welfare measures, can have too much surplus left to carry out capex (capital expenditure) work. That is done through loans or through public-private partnership, which we aim to strengthen," adds Chaudhary.

Political Challenges

The one big challenge for Vishnu Deo is, of course, on the political front. The newly anointed CM will have to put up a good show in the upcoming Lok Sabha election. The BJP won nine out of the 11 seats in the 2019 parliamentary election at a time when the Congress held a brute majority in the assembly (68 out of 90 seats)—signifying a clear voter preference for PM Modi. The Chhattisgarh unit of the Congress, however, doesn't seem to be down and out. In sharp contrast to neighbouring Madhya Pradesh, no major Congress leader has crossed over to the BJP yet. Moreover, in the 2023 assembly polls, the Congress managed to win 35 seats, mostly in the central plains region, and won 42 per cent of the vote share as against the BJP's 46 per cent.

Also, in its first round of ticket distribution, the Congress announced six out of 11 candidates, with former CM Bhupesh Baghel to contest from Rajnandgaon and former minister Tamradhwaj Sahu from Mahasamund. The BJP is wary about the threat.

THE CONGRESS IS HARDLY A SPENT FORCE IN CHHATTISGARH AND CAN POSE A TOUGH CHALLENGE IN THE LS POLLS. BUT AN EXPERIENCED VISHNU DEO SAI SAYS THE BJP IS UNFAZED

However, Vishnu Deo, who has years of legislative and organisational experience—he has thrice been BJP state president—says the party is unfazed. "BJP workers are perpetually among the people and our organisation ensures that the party is ready for elections at any time. We will win all 11 seats," the chief minister says confidently.

But his real test will begin after the Lok Sabha election, when he will have to get down to the nuts and bolts of administering the state. This summer, the heat of public expectation may rival the state's routine high temperatures that make national news. Perhaps, Vishnu Deo's affable nature and cool exterior will defuse and disarm any early sign of disaffection. ■